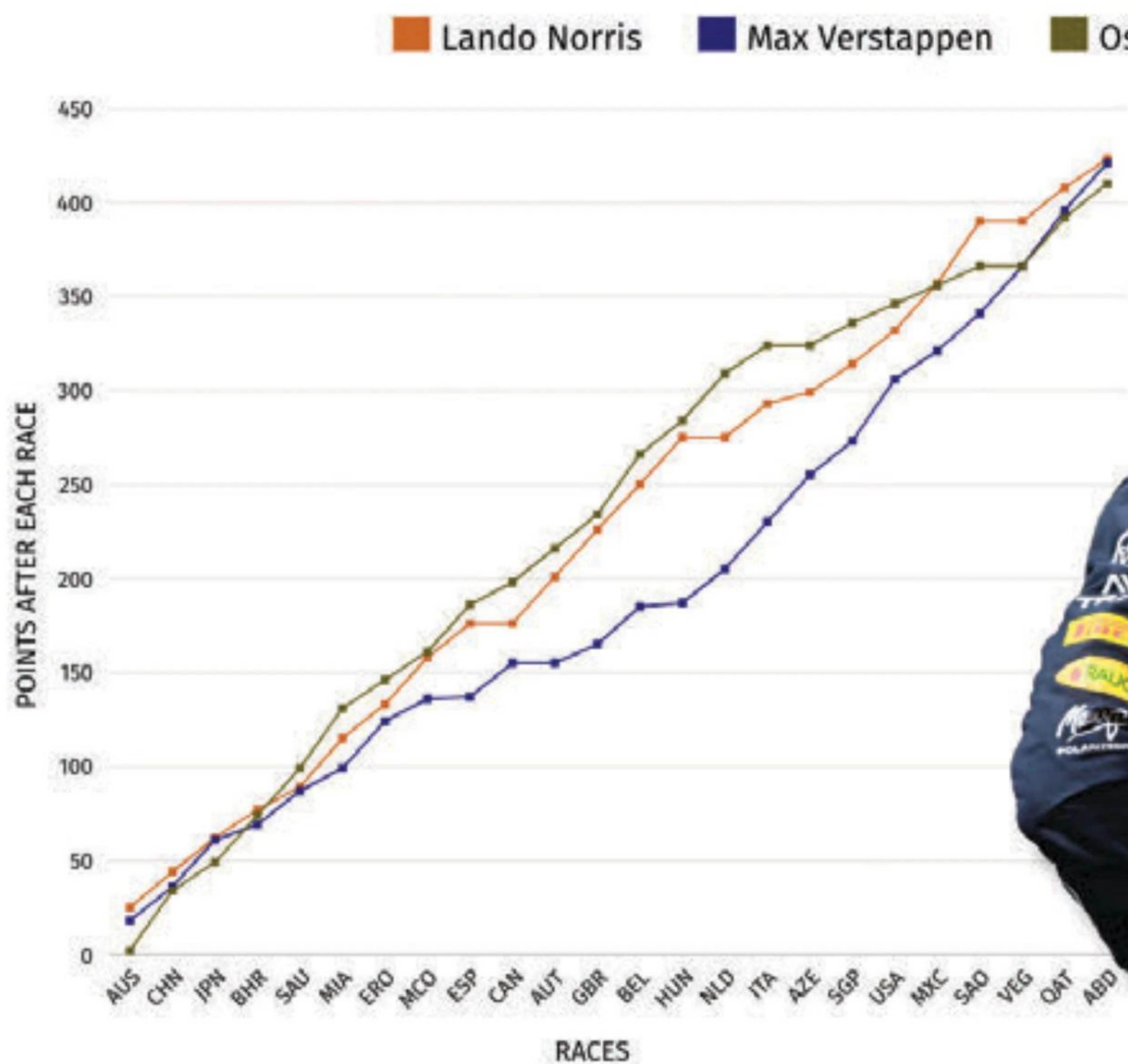




Chase master: Max Verstappen (left) mounted a remarkable late-season charge, closing rapidly on Norris. By the end of the final race, just two points separated them in the standings.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

without hurdles. Tense moments with his teammate, simmering dynamics within McLaren, and the resurgence of an unexpected yet anticipated rival tested him at every turn. Those challenges pushed the 26-year-old to adopt a steelier, more resolute mindset, a marked contrast to the jovial, easygoing youngster once celebrated as the sport's rising talent. In his seventh year in F1, he finally lived up to that promise, an achievement that had often felt distant.

Fleeting heights

Four races at the top, five at the end. That was all of Norris' time leading the championship, despite entering the season as the favourite. For 15

races in between, it was his teammate and rival, Piastri, who carved out his own ascent. The Australian emerged transformed after the heartbreaking season opener at home, sharpening his precision and resolve. His blend of aggression and adaptability fuelled a growing narrative: the grid might be witnessing its next world champion, perhaps at the expense of the man who had long carried McLaren's hopes.

Norris' slump after Australia strengthened Piastri's case, as the 24-year-old's rapid rise made the Briton's winless streak more glaring. Barring the curtain raiser, only a string of podiums kept Norris' fragile advantage intact. The Bahrain Grand Prix became his third consecutive weekend without the highest points haul, and he knew his position was under threat. His confidence faltered, and he did not shy away from voicing the doubts gnawing at him.

The next outing in Saudi Arabia marked the start of Piastri's

dominance and Norris' misery, as the former claimed his third triumph in five races and seized the all-important lead.

Narrow margins

Piastri, in only his third F1 season, produced a tenacious first quarter of the campaign. A driver whom few tipped to contend for the title was outshining his far more experienced teammate nearly every weekend. He went from an intriguing contender to a genuine favourite for the crown, but his next-door rival was never far behind.

Winning Monaco, widely considered the sport's crown jewel, offered a glimmer of hope for Norris. His first victory in six races cut the deficit to just three points, enough to keep belief alive.

But Canada shifted the dynamic. In Montreal, the two collided: Norris crashed out, and Piastri salvaged 12 points. It exposed the first public crack in the so-called papaya rules, McLaren's debated approach that